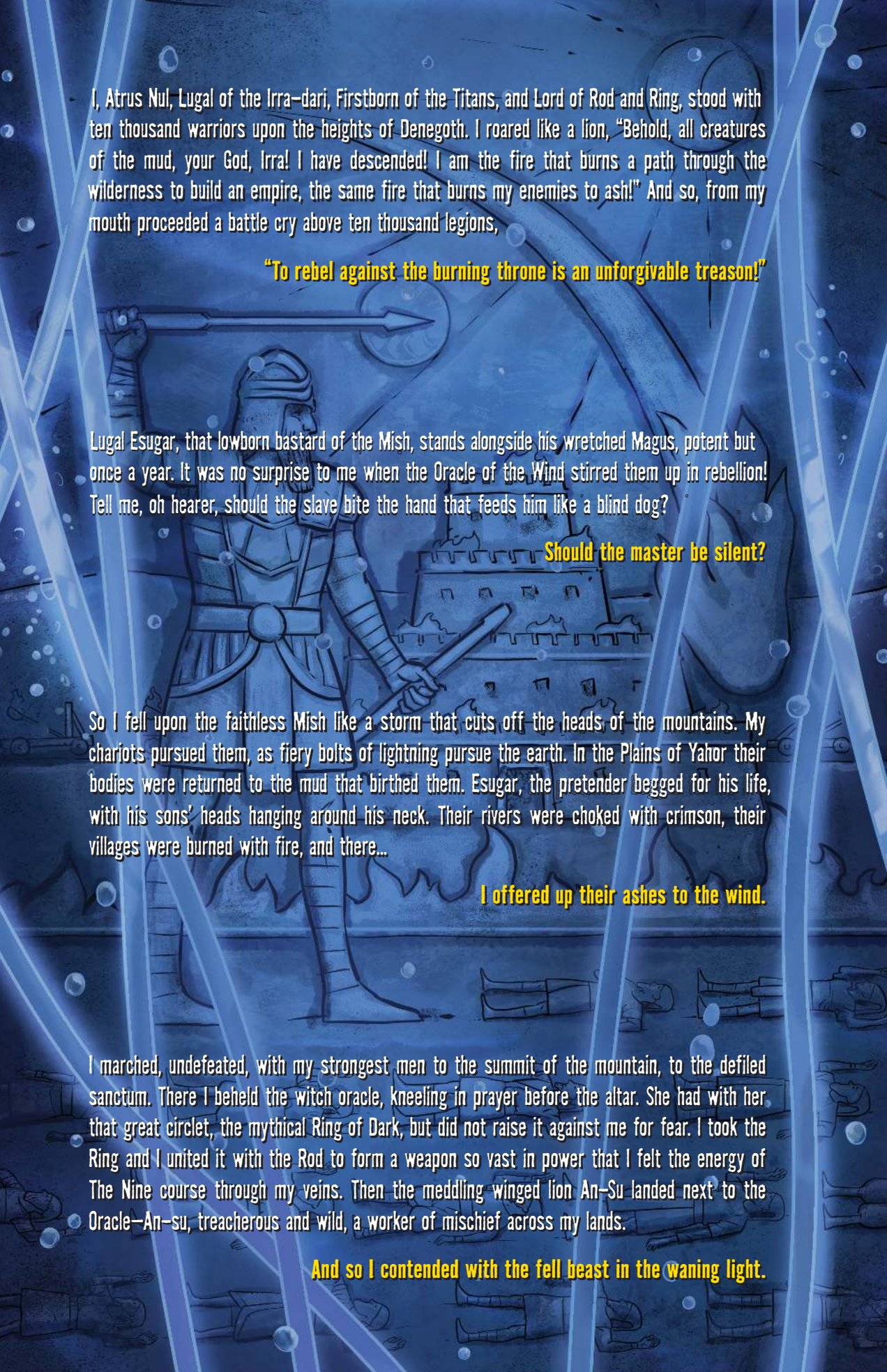




CHAPTER 3





I, Atrus Nul, Lugal of the Irra-dari, Firstborn of the Titans, and Lord of Rod and Ring, stood with ten thousand warriors upon the heights of Denegoth. I roared like a lion, "Behold, all creatures of the mud, your God, Irra! I have descended! I am the fire that burns a path through the wilderness to build an empire, the same fire that burns my enemies to ash!" And so, from my mouth proceeded a battle cry above ten thousand legions,

"To rebel against the burning throne is an unforgivable treason!"

Lugal Esugar, that lowborn bastard of the Mish, stands alongside his wretched Magus, potent but once a year. It was no surprise to me when the Oracle of the Wind stirred them up in rebellion! Tell me, oh hearer, should the slave bite the hand that feeds him like a blind dog?

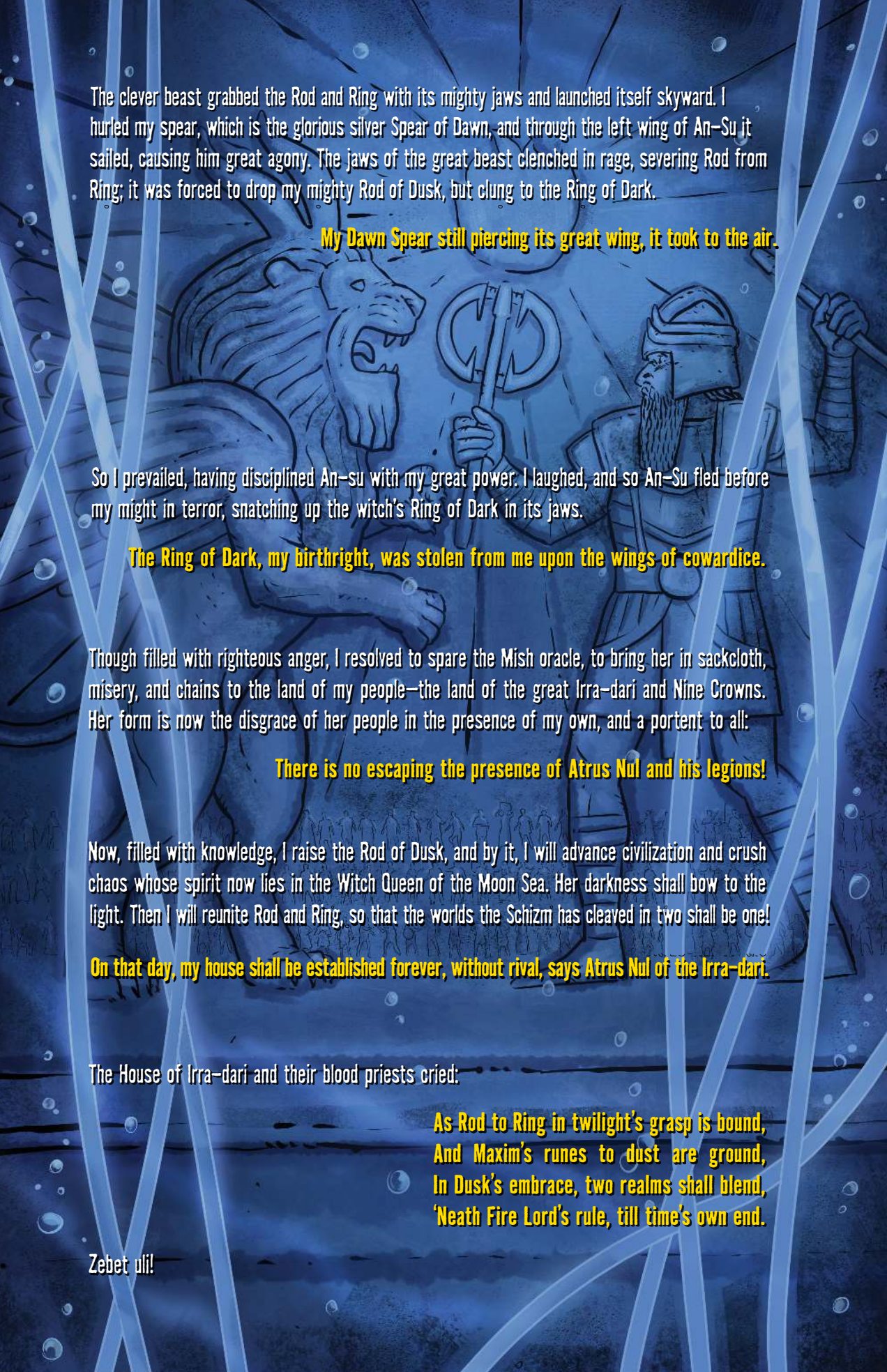
Should the master be silent?

So I fell upon the faithless Mish like a storm that cuts off the heads of the mountains. My chariots pursued them, as fiery bolts of lightning pursue the earth. In the Plains of Yahor their bodies were returned to the mud that birthed them. Esugar, the pretender begged for his life, with his sons' heads hanging around his neck. Their rivers were choked with crimson, their villages were burned with fire, and there...

I offered up their ashes to the wind.

I marched, undefeated, with my strongest men to the summit of the mountain, to the defiled sanctum. There I beheld the witch oracle, kneeling in prayer before the altar. She had with her that great circlet, the mythical Ring of Dark, but did not raise it against me for fear. I took the Ring and I united it with the Rod to form a weapon so vast in power that I felt the energy of The Nine course through my veins. Then the meddling winged lion An-Su landed next to the Oracle—An-su, treacherous and wild, a worker of mischief across my lands.

And so I contended with the fell beast in the waning light.



The clever beast grabbed the Rod and Ring with its mighty jaws and launched itself skyward. I hurled my spear, which is the glorious silver Spear of Dawn, and through the left wing of An-Su it sailed, causing him great agony. The jaws of the great beast clenched in rage, severing Rod from Ring; it was forced to drop my mighty Rod of Dusk, but clung to the Ring of Dark.

My Dawn Spear still piercing its great wing, it took to the air.

So I prevailed, having disciplined An-su with my great power. I laughed, and so An-Su fled before my might in terror, snatching up the witch's Ring of Dark in its jaws.

The Ring of Dark, my birthright, was stolen from me upon the wings of cowardice.

Though filled with righteous anger, I resolved to spare the Mish oracle, to bring her in sackcloth, misery, and chains to the land of my people—the land of the great Irra-dari and Nine Crowns. Her form is now the disgrace of her people in the presence of my own, and a portent to all:

There is no escaping the presence of Atrus Nul and his legions!

Now, filled with knowledge, I raise the Rod of Dusk, and by it, I will advance civilization and crush chaos whose spirit now lies in the Witch Queen of the Moon Sea. Her darkness shall bow to the light. Then I will reunite Rod and Ring, so that the worlds the Schizm has cleaved in two shall be one!

On that day, my house shall be established forever, without rival, says Atrus Nul of the Irra-dari.

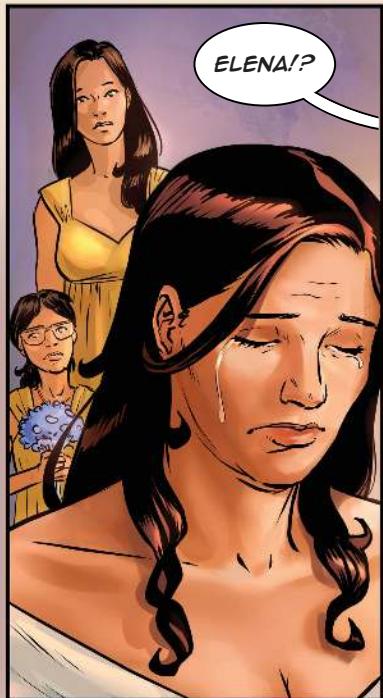
The House of Irra-dari and their blood priests cried:

**As Rod to Ring in twilight's grasp is bound,
And Maxim's runes to dust are ground,
In Dusk's embrace, two realms shall blend,
'Neath Fire Lord's rule, till time's own end.**

Zebet uli!



When I look back, I remember the stars and the quiet that precedes.





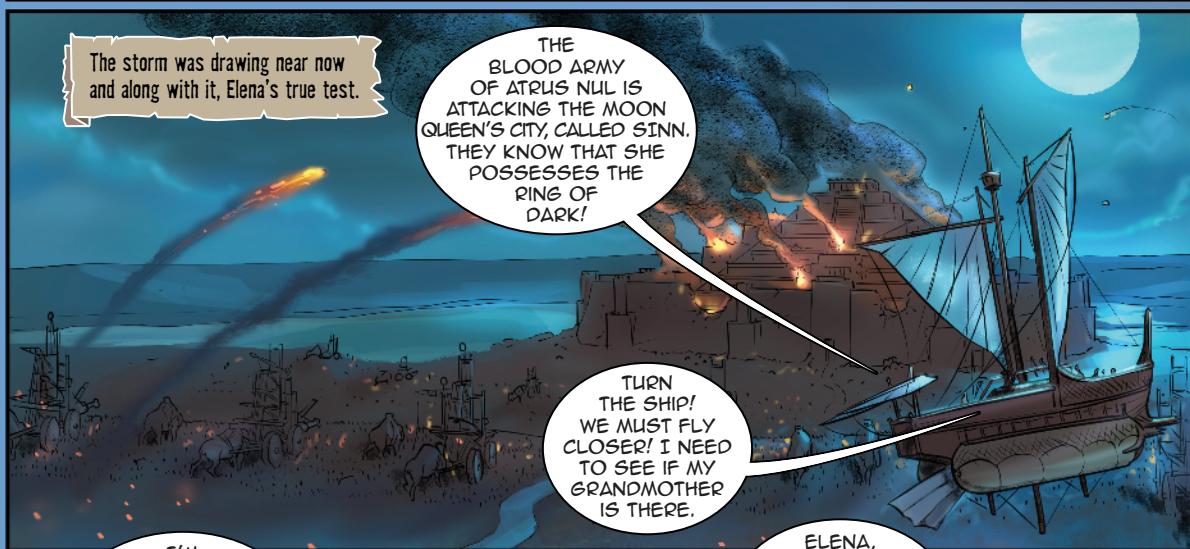
ELENA!?
TIME TO WAKE
UP!

WHA—
WHAT'S HAPPEN-
ING?



IT'S
WORSE THAN
WE PREDICTED,
ELENA. ATRUS NUL
HAS BROUGHT AN
ENORMOUS
ARMY.

OH
NO! — THIS
IS REAL ISN'T
IT?



The storm was drawing near now
and along with it, Elena's true test.

THE
BLOOD ARMY
OF ATRUS NUL IS
ATTACKING THE MOON
QUEEN'S CITY, CALLED SINN.
THEY KNOW THAT SHE
POSSESSES THE
RING OF
DARK!

TURN
THE SHIP!
WE MUST FLY
CLOSER! I NEED
TO SEE IF MY
GRANDMOTHER
IS THERE.



I'M
AFRAID SINN
WILL SOON FALL.
ITS WALLS ARE NO
MATCH FOR THESE
CATAPULTS!

ELENA,
TAKE THIS.
YOU AND THE
OTHERS MAY NEED
THIS ARMOR
SOON!





THAT
SHIP— IT'S
GOING TO
CRASH!

OH
NO! BUT
LOOK THERE!
DOMINION FORCES
HAVE BREACHED
THE OUTER
WALL!



THE
WAR MACHINE
OF ATRUS
NUL!

IS
THAT
HIM?!

THAT'S
HIM



BRACE
YOUR-
SELVES!

WE ARE
GOING TO CRASH
INTO ENEMY LINES!
WE MUST TRY AND
STEER OURSELVES
AWAY FROM
THEM.

UH!
WASN'T
THAT OUR
PILOT!?

I'LL
HOLD
THE SAILS
MYSELF!

VRA BOOM!



IF I CAN
JUST HIT THAT
WOOD BEAM,
MAYBE—

THOOK



GOOD
THINKING,
ELENA! SECOND
HARPOON
AWAY!

GOOD
SHOT!
THE SHIP IS
SLOWING!

SCHWOOSH



REPEL THEM! FIGHT FOR YOUR CITY! FIGHT FOR YOUR QUEEN!

GRAND-MOTHER? COULD IT BE?



WHO?

NEVER-MIND SHE IS TOO YOUNG— I THOUGHT—



WATCH OUT! INCOMING!

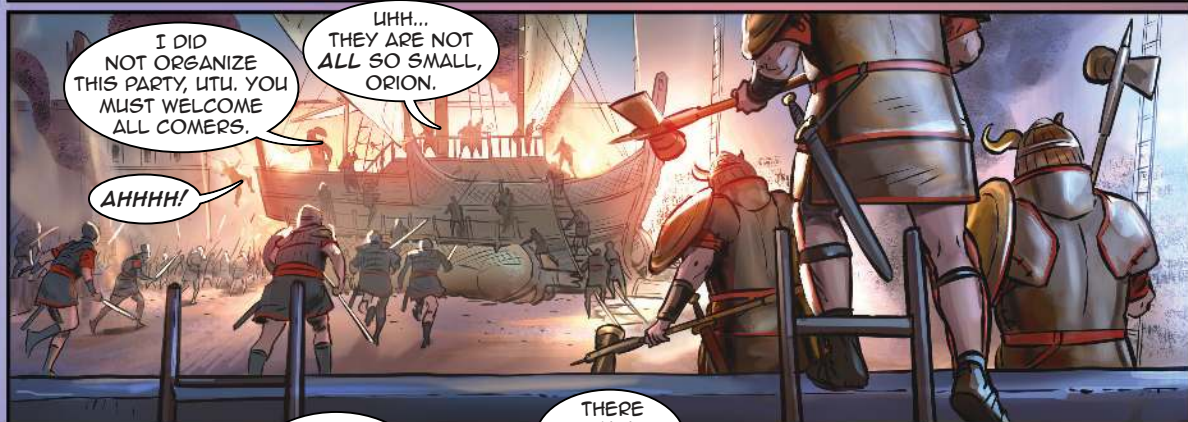


HOLD ON!

AHH!

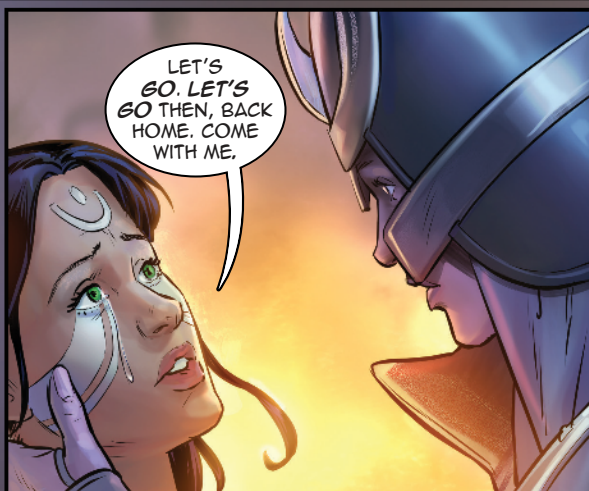
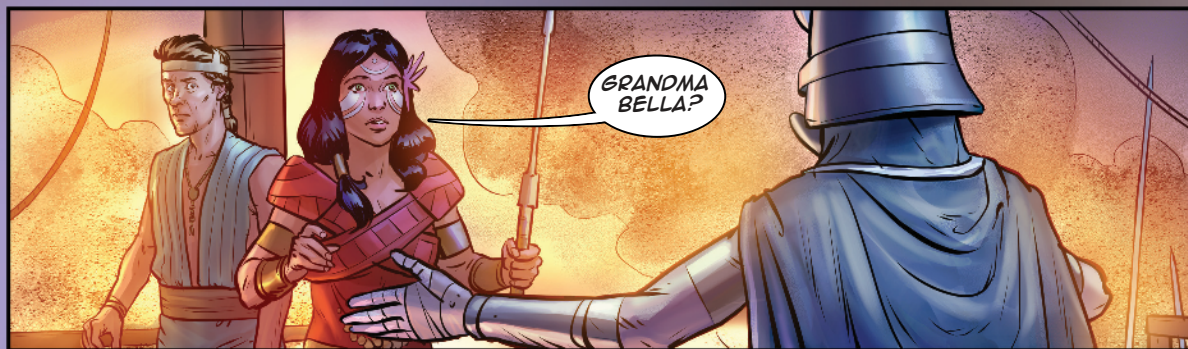


WE ARE GOING DOWN!







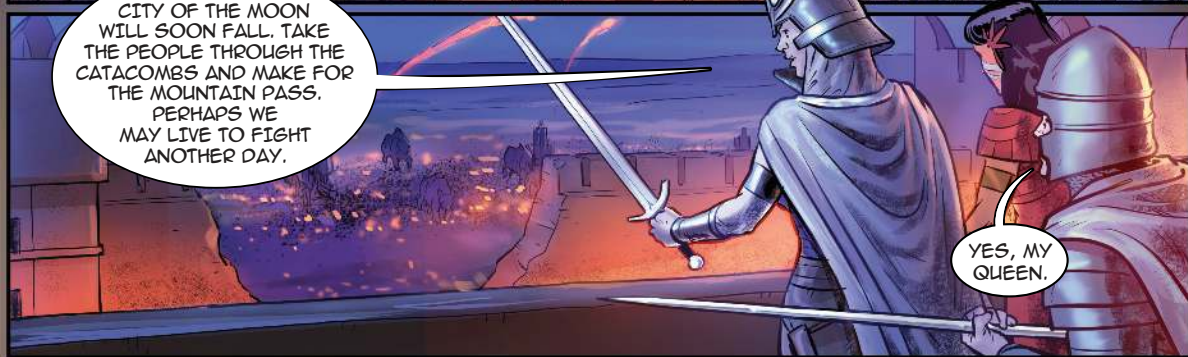




GET
THEM,
LADS!

ROUND
THEM UP! TAKE
THIS SCUM TO
THE MINES!

THE
CITY OF THE MOON
WILL SOON FALL. TAKE
THE PEOPLE THROUGH THE
CATACOMBS AND MAKE FOR
THE MOUNTAIN PASS.
PERHAPS WE
MAY LIVE TO FIGHT
ANOTHER DAY.



YES, MY
QUEEN.



HMM—
IF YOU CAN
BUY ME TEN MINUTES,
WE MIGHT BE ABLE
TO GET HER BACK
IN THE AIR.



MAKE
IT FIVE,
WE'VE GOT
TROUBLE

IRRA'S
BEARD. I'LL
DO THE BEST
I CAN.



THIS TIME,
WE ARE THE
WELCOMING
PARTY!



ELENA!
WATCH THE
WALL!

THWOSH

TRYING...!

MELCHIOR!
NOW WOULD
BE A GOOD
TIME!



NO!! THE PEOPLE!
LOOK!



WE
MUST HELP
THEM!

ELENA!
WE WILL ALL
DIE IF WE
STAY!



KROARRR



WHAT
THE—



PEACE,
ELENA. MUKRU,
MY MANTICORE,
IS HERE TO HELP
US!

A
MANTICORE?
GRANDMOTHER,
ARE YOU SURE
ABOUT THIS?



SO MUCH
DESTRUCTION—
SO MUCH
DEATH.



WE
LEAVE! TO
INDRUS
NA!



GOOD...
FOCUS, ELENA.
WHAT DO YOU
SEE? HIM!
ELENA!

**ELENA!!
AVOID HIS
GAZE!**

**SO MUCH
DESTRUCTION!
SO MUCH
DEATH!**

I'M OK.
BUT I CAN HEAR
IT AGAIN. THAT HORRIBLE
SOUND THAT FIRST
BROUGHT ME TO THE
HOLLOWLANDS. UHH!
I FEEL—

BTW





ENOUGH!
HOLD ON! IT
WILL SOON
PASS!



WE SEE
YOU TOO,
PRINCESS.



THE WITCH
ESCAPES WITH THE
RING OF DARK— NO
MATTER. THE TIME OF THE
PROPHESIED BLOOD
MOON IS UPON
US!



THE MOON
QUEEN HAS AN
OFFSPRING. WE MUST
EXPLOIT THIS
WEAKNESS.

INTERESTING...
TELL ME, SPIRIT.
WHAT DO YOU
PROPOSE?

DO YOU
BELIEVE IN
MIRACLES, MY
LORD?

ARE YOU
MEDDLING WITH
ME? I CANNOT KILL
YOU, BUT IT DOES NOT
MEAN I MUST ENDURE
YOUR RIDDLES.



PATIENCE,
DEAR LUGAL. FEAR
HAS A WAY OF EATING
AT THE MIND. PREPARE THE
RITUAL OF THE BLOOD
MOON. I WILL DELIVER
YOUR SACRIFICE
MYSELF.



LOOK—
SOME OLD
RUINS BELOW!
WHAT IS THIS
PLACE?

THIS IS
THE FORTRESS OF
INDRAS NA. BEYOND, YOU
CAN SEE THE DESTROYED
MOON BRIDGE THAT LEADS
TO THE DARK LANDS
OF KUR.

We arrived at the old gateway to the
underworld of Kur, now ruined, but
still beckoning to the dead.



GRANDMA
BELLA, WE
SHOULDN'T BE HERE.
WE NEED TO GO
HOME.

ELENA,
IF WE DON'T
STOP THE SON OF
WAR, ATRUS NUL, THERE
WILL BE NO HOME
TO GO BACK
TO.



HELP ME
UNDERSTAND.
WHAT ARE YOU DOING
HERE? WHY WON'T
YOU COME BACK
TO US?

MY BODY
IS FADING THERE.
I'M MUCH STRONGER
HERE. I HAVE TO STOP
ATRUS NUL— SOON
YOU'LL KNOW
WHY.



YOU FIGHT
WELL, ELENA. I
ONCE WIELDED
THE WEAPON
YOU DO.

WHY
DID YOU
GIVE IT UP
TO ME?

IT
PROVED
TOO MUCH.
ITS WEIGHT
PAINED ME.



GRANDMA,
IS THERE NO OTHER
WAY? CAN WE GO BACK
HOME AND RETURN
WITH HELP?



NO, MY
CHILD. THEY
WON'T BELIEVE
US. THEY DON'T
BELIEVE THIS
PLACE IS
REAL.

HMM...
ANOTHER
POOL?

WHY DID
YOU LEAVE US
FOR THIS PLACE
WHICH PROBABLY
ISN'T EVEN
REAL?



I
LEFT YOU
TO PROTECT
YOU, SWEET
ONE.



DON'T YOU
SEE, ELENA? OUR
HOME IS A REFLECTION OF
THIS WORLD. AARON AND THE
OTHERS BELIEVE THE HOLLOWLANDS
IS A SIMULATION. IT'S NOT. THEY
HOPED TO USE US TO THEIR
ADVANTAGE, BUT I WILL USE
THEIR IGNORANCE TO
OUR BENEFIT.

JUST
PROMISE YOU
WILL COME HOME
AFTER WE TRY TO
STOP THIS ATRUS
NUL. OK?



OK—
SOUNDS
TERRIFYING BUT
I'M READY TO
LEARN.

I WILL,
SWEET ONE—
NOW LET ME TEACH
YOU HOW TO USE THAT
WEAPON TO *YOUR*
ADVANTAGE.

THE DAWN
SPEAR— IT'S MORE THAN
IT SEEMS. ISIN ADA DIDN'T
TEACH YOU THIS? I SEE THAT
I MUST TRAIN YOU FOR WHAT
IS TO COME. THERE IS
MUCH YOU DON'T
KNOW.

ISIN
ADA HAS FORESEEN THAT
IF ATRUS NUL JOINS ROD AND
RING, HE WILL TRY TO PIERCE THE VEIL
- OUR WORLDS WILL BECOME ONE.
MACHINES WILL BECOME LIFELESS
STATUES AS THE LUGAL'S MAGICIANS
WREST CONTROL OF THEIR ELECTRICAL
IMPULSES; ENTIRE ARMIES WILL STAND
CONFOUNDED BY WORDS OF POWER
ECHOING IN THEIR
MINDS....

WORDS
OF POWER?
UH... OK.

THE PEOPLE
OF EARTH WILL COWER
BEFORE UNDEAD ARMIES RAISED
UP BY NECROMANCERS. YOU MUST
UNDERSTAND, ELENA. PEOPLE ARE
DESTROYED BY WHAT THEY DO NOT
UNDERSTAND. IN THAT DAY, IF ATRUS
NUL HAS HIS WAY... BOTH OUR
WORLD AND THEIRS WILL BE
CONTAMINATED BY FORBIDDEN
KNOWLEDGE.

OK, I
THINK I GET IT
NOW— AND *THAT'S*
WHY YOU WANTED
ME TO FIND YOU
HERE?

I CAN'T DO
THIS ALONE. I NEED YOU,
ELENA, TO BRING BALANCE
BACK. OUR WORLD CAN NEVER
KNOW ABOUT THIS PLACE,
OR THE MAGIC IT HOLDS.
WILL YOU LEARN
FROM ME?

BRAVERY
DOESN'T COME
NATURALLY BUT I
WILL TRY,
GRANDMA



THE DAWN SPEAR HIDES SECRETS. SEPARATE THE POWER, ELENA. USE IT NOT AS ONE, BUT TWO!

CAN YOU SHOW ME?



THE SPEAR OBEYS THE MIND OF ITS MASTER. YOU MUST *CHANGE* WHAT YOU BELIEVE TO UNLOCK ITS TRUE POWER. *LISTEN*: THE TRUTH LIES BETWEEN THE LINES OF SEPARATION. FLEE THE LIGHT TO FIND IT, *EMBRACE THE COLD AND BITTER BITE!*

UH... OK. I'LL TRY.



WOAH... I DON'T KNOW HOW, BUT IT TURNED INTO A FLAIL THINGY.

GOOD! REMEMBER THIS WEAPON IS ALIVE, ELENA. IT ALSO LISTENS.



THIS IS JUST THE BEGINNING. THE SPEAR HAS MORE SECRETS THAT YOU WILL DISCOVER AS YOU LISTEN.



GOOD! AGAIN!



AS CLOSE AS A SHADOW, THERE IS A WARRIOR IN YOU.



Indeed, in that very hour, shadows were drawing near.



COMMANDER,
ORGANIZE AID FOR
THE WOUNDED. SEE
TO IT THAT EVERYONE
HAS FOOD AND
A PLACE TO
SHELTER.

RIGHT
AWAY, MY
QUEEN!



ORION,
WE SHOULD BE
CAREFUL. ELENA'S
SPEAR AND SABELLA'S
RING TOGETHER
COULD PROVE
DANGEROUS.

GOOD!...
WE NEED MORE
DANGEROUS ON
OUR SIDE.



YOU KNOW
THE ORACLE'S
PROPHECY LIKE I DO.
IF THESE FALL INTO THE
WRONG HANDS—
IT'S OVER.

LISTEN,
SHORT LEGS.
WHY DO YOU COWER
BEHIND SUPER-
STITION?



I'M JUST
SAYIN'... HOW CAN
I SIN ADA TRUST QUEEN
SABELLA AFTER
WHAT SHE DID
TO US?



LIGH...
AGAIN WITH
THAT FEELING...
WHAT IS LUTU
HIDING?



WE NEED
ALL OUR SHIPS
BACK IN THE AIR AS
SOON AS POSSIBLE.
THIS FIGHT IS FAR
FROM OVER!

YES, MY
QUEEN!

CAN THIS
BE THE SAME
GRANDMA I
REMEMBER AS
A CHILD?





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